

The Teen Edition of Why Is This Still Here?

Everyone Had One. Where Did They All Go?

Why Fads End, and Why Some Things Don't

—	Before You Start	4
—	Opening — Five Hundred and a Thousand Years	9
Part One · They're Two Different Things		18
1	A Trend and a Keeper	21
2	Three Clocks	31
3	The Spot Where Customers Are New Every Year	44
Part Two · The Ones That Vanished		55
4	The Fad Was the Lifespan	58
5	Nowhere Left to Use It	73
6	It Died by Growing	87
Part Three · The Ones That Stayed		104
7	It Changed Clocks	109
8	The Shape Became the Name	124

9	The Season Sells It for You	138
Part Four · The Late Arrivals		151
10	The World Arrived Late	154
11	It Survived by Changing What It Was For	166
12	When an Old Thing Suddenly Becomes New ..	177
Part Five · So What Do You Make		188
13	How to See What's Stuck	191
14	Making a Reason to Act Now	201
15	The Order You Build the Four Bridges In	212
16	A Game You Can Start Late	224
—	Closing — What Will Still Be in Your Hands in Ten Years	237
—	How This Was Made — What Was Confirmed and What Wasn't Used	246

Before You Start

★ What this book does

One line:

Selling big and selling for a long time are two different things, and there's a way to tell which is which.

Selling big is a **bestseller**. Short and loud. Selling for a long time is a **steady seller**. Quiet and it doesn't stop.

Neither word is only about books. Clothes, food, games, videos — everything splits the same way.

Five parts:

Part	What it covers
One (ch 1 - 3)	They're different things — how to tell
Two (ch 4 - 6)	The ones that vanished — why they ended
Three (ch 7 - 9)	The ones that stayed — why they didn't
Four (ch 10 - 12)	The late arrivals — failed, then came back
Five (ch 13 - 16)	So what do you make

Every chapter ends with **Do This Today**. Reading and closing the book means forgetting it, so do them.

★ This isn't a business book

Part Five talks about making things, but nobody is telling you to open a shop.

Whatever you make, this applies. Videos, drawings, a club, the way you study.

What makes a thing last is pretty much the same everywhere.

★ There's a grown-up version

There's an adult book called *Why Is This Still Here?* It says the same things across twenty chapters, in more detail.

You don't need it. This book stands on its own.

Where a chapter has more behind it, there's a line pointing at the adult version.

★ A lot of names are missing on purpose

You'll hit sentences like this a lot:

"a company" "an old song" "a shop in one district"

That's deliberate.

Where something was confirmed, it says so.

Where it wasn't, the name is gone. **Pretending to know is the worst thing a book can do.**

Every chapter that uses a real case ends with **Where This Came From**. It lists two things:

One, what was confirmed. **Two**, what could *not* be confirmed and was therefore **left out**.

Almost no book prints the second list. It's the more useful one.

And to be honest about it: confirmed here means public sources cross-checked against each other. It does not mean anyone opened a company's filing cabinet. That's stated too.

★ Numbers and years

Treat numbers as **direction**, not as exact values.

Exact values move.

There's almost no "these days" or "this year" in this book. It should still read correctly in ten years.

Checking things yourself is one of the habits this book is trying to teach.

Opening — Five Hundred and a Thousand Years

★ Five hundred shops in two years

There was a shop everyone queued for.

Fruit dipped in hardened sugar, on a stick. One year it was suddenly everywhere. Every side street had one.

The company put out an announcement. Two years in, it had opened its five hundredth shop.

Seven months later the count was four hundred and ninety.

Not up. Down.

Across three months that same year, from spring into early summer, a hundred and twenty-seven

shops in that trade closed nationwide.

And the closing got faster every month. Eleven in the first month, twenty-eight two months later, forty-nine the month after that.

Seven months from the party for shop number five hundred.

★ One thing for a thousand years

Now a different shop.

It sits on the approach road to a shrine in Kyoto.
It sells one thing: grilled rice cakes.

It has reportedly been on that spot since around the year 1000.

The person running it now is the twenty-fifth generation.

The most striking thing about this shop isn't what it sells. It's **what it refuses to do.**

No department store counters. No festival stalls.
No new items. No branches.

The family's explanation is one line. **Not growing the business is the policy.**

And once you see *why* the shop is in that particular spot, you have most of this book.

The shrine in front of it draws people who come to pray.

They come every year. And **every year they are different people.** That flow has not broken in a thousand years.

★ Put the two numbers side by side

Five hundred, and a thousand years.

The first number is big. The second is slow. The first took two years. The second took ten centuries.

The usual question here is:

Which one was better at business?

That question being wrong is where this book starts.

Put them on one line and no answer comes out. One made a lot. One made it for a long time. Those aren't values you can compare.

It isn't that one did well and one did badly. They did different work.

One sold what people were talking about. The other sold what people keep needing.

Talk ends. Need doesn't.

So one earned big and finished, and the other earned small and didn't finish.

★ This happens in your classroom too

You don't have to go to Kyoto.

Think of the one thing everyone in your class had last year.

Who has one now?

That's the five hundred.

Now think of something in the same room that's been there for years. Nobody calls it a trend. Everybody uses it.

That's the thousand years.

They were in the same room at the same time.

And their lifespans were nothing alike.

Sixteen chapters on where that difference comes from.

★ This book does not take a side

Saying it up front:

This is not a book where trends are bad and lasting is good.

Sometimes you should go loud. Sometimes that's the correct move. Plenty of good things ended unknown because nobody went loud.

There's exactly one thing this book is against:

Preparing to take off and not preparing to land.

Everything in Part Two split right there.

★ The ending, in advance

Here's a sentence from the end of the book, now.
Knowing it makes the rest read better.

Most things that lasted were not planned to last.
They just never went away.

Why is that good news?

Planning favors people who are good at planning.
Not going away favors people who don't quit.

And that's a much better game for you.

Chapter 16 does that properly.

★ Where this came from

This book is careful with company names and product names. **Names age.** The rule is spelled out in the next piece.

The rule applies to this opening too, so no names appear above. Here's what to check them against.

1. The five-hundredth-shop announcement by the sugared-fruit chain, and its shop count seven months later. Company announcements and franchise disclosure filings.
2. Closures across that whole trade and the month-by-month trend. Korean Ministry of the Interior and Safety local-permit data.
3. Ichiwa (一文字屋和輔), the grilled rice cake shop by Imamiya Shrine in Kyoto: founding period, current generation, and the no-expansion policy. The shop's own material and its Guinness World Records entry.

All three are public sources cross-checked. No original filings were opened. That belongs in the record too.

Part One • They're Two Different Things

★ Three chapters

Every tool this book uses comes out here. **Three** clocks and **four** bridges. That's all of it.

Part One has no company names and no product names. That's on purpose. **Names** **age**.

A name everybody knows now will need explaining in a few years, and an example that needs explaining slows you down instead of helping.

Names start in Part Two. They're needed there.

★ The order

Chapter	What it asks
1	What's the difference between a trend and a thing people keep using?
2	Why do some things get old fast and some never do?
3	Why doesn't a shop die when customers don't come back?

Chapter 1 splits the two. Chapter 2 builds the ruler that splits them. Chapter 3 shows how the lasting side actually runs.

After three chapters you can pick up any object and explain it in this book's words.

Chapter 1 · A Trend and a Keeper

★ A bookshop has two spots

Walk into a bookshop. Right at the entrance there's a big table with books lying flat, covers facing up.

Most of those books are gone in three months.

Twenty steps further in there are shelves. Books standing upright, only their spines showing.

Some of those have been in the same slot for ten years.

Twenty steps between the two spots. And they are two different businesses.

The entrance is how a bookshop **earns**. The back is how it **survives**.

Same building, same product. Why does it split?

★ The usual thought — the ones that sold well survived

The idea is that the best of the big sellers stick around and become the long sellers.

That's less than half right.

Some do survive, sure. The rate is very low. And there's something more important.

A lot of long sellers didn't sell at all at first.

If that's true, you can't put the two on one line.

They're not first place and last place. They're different tests.

★ What a trend actually sells

Look closely at something selling in huge numbers. It isn't only the object moving around.

People are talking about it. To be in that conversation you have to have one.

A trend sells the right to be in the conversation.

That has a funny property:

Selling a lot is itself the reason it sells more.

"Everyone's buying it" becomes the thing people say, and saying it makes more people buy it. Past a certain point it rolls by itself.

And it ends for exactly the same reason.

Talk loses value the more times you hear it. To the person hearing it for the third time, it's nothing.

When the conversation ends, the reason to buy ends. The object didn't change. The reason disappeared.

★ What a keeper sells

Long sellers are usually not conversation. Almost nobody talks about them.

What they have instead is this:

There's a specific moment when not having one is a problem.

Winter arrives. Exams arrive. You move. You do something alone for the first time.

Those moments don't pick favorites. Every year the same moment arrives for different people.

A keeper is the thing standing in that spot.

It sells not because it's being discussed, but because the moment came and it was there.

A trend bets on what people are talking about now. A keeper bets on when people get stuck.

★ Draw them

Draw the two and the shapes are nothing alike.

A trend is a peak. Straight up, straight down. Tall and narrow.

A keeper is a plain. You can't see it rise. Low, wide, and nobody remembers when it started.

Here's where people get it wrong.

Peaks are visible and plains aren't, so peaks look bigger.

The area under the plain is often larger.

The problem is that you only find that out ten years later. So at the moment of choosing, the peak always looks bigger.

★ The money runs the opposite way

More important than the shapes:

A trend costs more the more it sells.

Talk is its fuel, and cutting fuel kills it immediately. So you have to keep spending while it sells. Peak sales are peak spending.

A keeper barely costs more when it sells more.

People come looking for it. It just has to be sitting where the question gets asked.

Stop promoting it for a year and not much changes. That one line is what separates what the two businesses keep.

★ So are trends bad?

No. This book doesn't say that.

There are three things only a trend gives you.

One, speed. It builds in three months what a plain takes ten years to build.

Two, visibility. People find out the thing exists. However good it is, nothing happens if nobody knows.

Three, it's a doorway into being a keeper.

A lot of today's long sellers were once enormous trends. They didn't come down off the peak. They moved onto the plain.

Part Three is entirely about that.

So the problem isn't aiming for a trend.

The problem is preparing to take off and not deciding where you're going afterwards.

★ The short version

	Trend	Keeper
Sells	conversation	the answer at a moment
Why it sells	it sold, so it sells	the moment came round again

	Trend	Keeper
Who buys	whoever's in the conversation	whoever hit that moment this year
Selling more	wears the talk out	sets the name harder
Stop promoting	dies immediately	barely moves
Shape	tall narrow peak	low wide plain
Why it ends	the conversation ended	the moment stopped existing

Read the last row again.

A keeper usually doesn't end because something better showed up. It ends when the situation it was standing in disappears.

Part Two uses that sentence as its ruler.

★ Do This Today

Pick up three objects within reach. Not expensive ones — near ones.

Write one line on each: why you got it. Then tag it:

- **Talk** — everyone was talking about it
- **Answer** — something came up and you needed it

Then one last question.

Of the three, which ones do you actually still use?

They usually cluster on one side. That side is the side you should be making.

Chapter 2 · Three Clocks

★ Everything in your house is a different age

The iron pan in the kitchen might be twenty years old. The phone in your pocket is about two. The yogurt in the fridge is three days old and gone in three more.

All three were bought with money. Their lifespans differ by a factor of over a thousand.

It isn't price. The phone cost more than the pan. It isn't durability. Phones usually get replaced before they break.

Different clocks are running inside different objects.

This chapter counts them. There are three.

★ The usual thought — make it well and it lasts

The idea is that quality decides lifespan.

Half right.

Quality decides **how long the thing holds up.**

Lifespan is decided by **how long people keep wanting it.**

There's something in your house that works fine and nobody uses. It wasn't put away because it broke. It was put away because the wanting stopped.

So the question changes.

Not "how long does this last" but "how long does wanting this last."

That wanting runs on three cycles.

★ One • The fashion clock — months

This clock runs on what other people are doing right now.

So its cycle is short. The moment everyone has one, the value is gone.

Things on the fashion clock share one property:

Having one alone is no fun.

The value isn't inside the object. It's in your relation to everyone else. When they stop caring, the one in your hand loses value too.

That thing that went round your class and then suddenly nobody did — that's this clock.

Things on this clock make money fast. And nobody knows when they'll stop.

Not knowing when is the real danger of this clock.

★ Two • The generation clock — ten to thirty years

Some things get into you when you're young. A familiar sound, a familiar taste, a familiar shape of clothing.

This doesn't turn over in months like fashion. It also isn't forever.

It ages as those people age.

Here's the frightening part:

Nobody standing on this clock thinks they're standing on fashion.

If you think it's a fad you prepare for the end. If you think it's taste, you don't.

It hasn't changed in over ten years, so it looks like it never will. That belief usually gets proved wrong around year fifteen.

The generation clock is the easiest one to be fooled by.

Think about the music your parents like. To them it isn't a fad. It's good music.

★ Three • The need clock — it doesn't turn

Cold. Hungry. Sleepy. Hurt. Bored. Lonely.
Wanting to show someone. Wanting to pass something on.

That list was the same a hundred years ago. It won't be very different in a hundred more.

This clock doesn't turn.

There's one very important condition attached:

Needs don't change. The way a need gets met changes constantly.

Keeping warm doesn't change. What you keep warm with keeps changing. Getting news to someone far away doesn't change. What you send it with has changed many times.

So sitting on the need clock takes care.

Hold onto a method and you disappear with the method. Hold onto the need and you stay with the need.

That sentence appears more than any other in this book. Mark it.

★ All three clocks live inside every category

This clears up a common mistake.

The category doesn't set the clock. Clothes aren't fashion because they're clothes.

All three clocks exist inside one category.

Category	Fashion clock	Generation clock	Need clock
Clothes	this year's cut	what that generation wore	thermals, socks, underwear
Food	the queued-for dessert	the taste of being small	rice, water, salt
Music	the song of that	that generation	lullabies, holiday

Category	Fashion clock	Generation clock	Need clock
	summer	's sound	songs
Books	this year's talked-about title	that generation's required reading	dictionary, cookbooks, scripture
Devices	the new standard	the way that generation learned	fire, water, light

Read that table across, not down.

Clothes and books are completely different categories. Things in the same column behave identically.

Thermal underwear and a dictionary are on the same clock. Both sell every year with no advertising. Neither has ever been news.

The clock decides an object's fate, not the category.

★ Reading the clock wrong

Two mistakes. They point in opposite directions.

One. Spending long money on the fashion clock.

Buying equipment, signing a lease, buying things meant to last years. The trend ends, the revenue goes, and the equipment stays.

That's Chapter 6. It is the most common way to go under.

Two. Selling a need-clock thing like a trend.

Pushing urgency, changing it often, making limited editions.

The value of a need-clock thing comes from the fact that it doesn't change. The belief that this year's is the same as last year's is the asset.

Keep changing it and you're shaving down your own asset.

The first mistake loses money. The second loses time. And you can't buy time back.

★ You can change clocks

That's the diagnosis. A diagnosis alone doesn't tell you what to do.

Luckily clocks aren't fixed.

Things that started on the fashion clock have moved onto the need clock.

There are only four bridges across. The names go here; how to build them is Part Three.

Bridge	What it asks
Repeat	Do you buy another when it runs out?
Shape	Do people recognize it without being told?
Patina	Does it get better with use?
Handoff	Can it pass to someone else?

Things with two or more of the four last. One bridge is a season. Zero is this month.

★ The short version

	Fashion clock	Generation clock	Need clock
Cycle	months	10 - 30 years	doesn't turn
Runs on	what others do	when you grew up	the body and life
Value sits in	your relation to others	memory	the trouble of a moment
Main danger	no idea when it stops	not knowing it's fashion	mistaking method for need

None of the three clocks is good or bad. Deciding without knowing which one you're on — that's the bad part.

★ Do This Today

Walk through your house and pick five objects. Include the oldest one and the most recent one.

Next to each, write when you got it and which clock it's on.

Then the last question.

The most recent one — will it still be in this house in ten years?

If you answered yes, write one line saying why.

If that line names one of the four bridges, your answer is probably right.

Chapter 3 • The Spot Where Customers Are New Every Year

★ A shop nobody returns to is twenty years old

There's a shop that sells baby things.

A customer usually comes once and then stops coming after a few years. Once the child grows, there's nothing there to buy.

Almost no regulars. The owner rarely learns a face.

That shop has been on that spot for twenty years.

The cafe across the street is the opposite. There are people who come every day and the owner knows their names.

And the owner changes every few years.

Strange. The one without regulars stays. The one with regulars closes.

★ The usual thought — lasting requires regulars

Half right.

Regulars are good. They are not the condition for lasting.

There's only one condition for lasting:

New customers keep appearing.

The same people coming back is one way.

Different people coming is also a way.

The second way gets talked about far less. And most things that last are living on the second way.

★ Stacking customers and rotating customers

There are two kinds of customer.

Stacking. They stay and add up. This month sits on top of last month.

Rotating. They turn over. This month isn't last month's people.

	Stacking	Rotating
Customers	pile up	turn over
When it's going well	grows fast	doesn't grow
When it's going badly	shrinks fast	doesn't shrink
If you stop	they leak out	it stays put

	Stacking	Rotating
What it needs	holding on	being there

The two middle rows are the point.

The stacking side has to grow to live. Stop growing and trouble starts. The rotating side doesn't grow, and it doesn't shrink.

Not growing sounds like a flaw. It also means not shrinking.

★ Think about doors

Rotating customers don't appear anywhere. They appear at **the places in a life that repeat.**

This book calls those places **doors.**

Starting secondary school. Going somewhere alone for the first time. Selling something for the

first time. The first exam that actually matters.
The first job.

These doors open every year. And every year
different people are standing in front of them.

You stood at a door last year, and this year
someone else is standing there.

People at a door have three things in common.

One, it's their first time, so they don't know. They
ask instead of choosing.

Two, they're in a hurry. Term already started; the
exam is next week. They don't compare for long.

Three, they're afraid of getting it wrong. First time
means not knowing what's risky, so they pick the
safe thing.

Put those three together and the competition changes completely.

At a door, the better thing doesn't win. The first thing to come to mind wins.

★ Being what comes to mind

Call that position the default.

It's an extremely strong place to stand. It doesn't sell because it's better than the rest. It sells because it's the answer to a question.

This position has an odd property:

You can't buy it.

Defaults aren't made by advertising. They're made by what the people who already went through that door said.

The one who went first tells the next one. That piles up, and it becomes default.

So it takes time. And that's why it's hard to take.

Someone new can build a better thing. They cannot build ten years of what people said on their way through.

★ So why is such a good spot empty

Being honest here.

If this spot is so good, why isn't everyone crowding into it?

Because it's boring.

Rotating customers don't spike. This year and next year look the same. In numbers there's nothing to brag about. Nothing to announce.

People with money to invest want to see growth.
So that kind of money doesn't come here.

Competition is thin here not because it's hard to
get in but because it doesn't look impressive.

Remember that sentence. Chapter 16, the last
thing this book says, grows out of it.

Where big money doesn't come, whoever stays
longest wins. And staying costs less than growing
does.

★ When these customers end

Rotating customers end too. They end differently.

It's rare for a competitor to end them. The door
closes.

If people stop hitting that situation, it's over. If they still hit it but stop solving it with your thing, also over.

The line from the last chapter comes back:

Needs don't change; methods do.

Did the door close, or is the door open and something else became the answer? **Telling those two apart is Part Two's job.**

So the one thing a long seller checks every year is this:

Not who the competitors are. Whether that door is still open.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
Who's the customer	whoever hit that door for the first time this year
Why they buy	first time, in a hurry, afraid of being wrong
What wins	not the better one — the one that comes to mind
How you get there	what people who went through piled up
Why competition is thin	no growth. Doesn't look impressive
When it ends	not competition — when the door closes

★ Do This Today

Think of something you did for the first time in the last year. It doesn't have to be big. First time is enough.

Write down what you bought. Then write how you found out about it.

- I saw an ad
- I searched
- I asked someone

Which of the three?

If you found out by asking, that thing is sitting in the default spot.

Then one last question.

Is the thing you're making something people would tell each other about when they hit something for the first time?

If not, you haven't found the door yet. Finding a door costs time, not money.

Part Two · The Ones That Vanished

★ Why start with the dead ones

Three chapters. This is where names first appear in this book.

Starting with survivors feels good. You learn less.

Line up only the survivors and **too many things look shared**. It was a good product, they got lucky, people loved it. All true, all useless.

Start with the ones that vanished and it changes.

Those were good products too, and people loved them too.

A trait the dead ones also had can't be the reason
the live one lived.

Part Two does that filtering. When Part Three
looks at survivors, the already-filtered traits don't
count.

★ Same order each time

when it broke out → what was selling →
when it turned → what got cut first

The last box is the one that matters.

When something collapses, several things collapse
at once and the cause hides. Finding the one thing
that got cut first is the job of this part.

★ Three ways to die

Chapter	What got cut first	The product was
4	the talk — the conversation ended	fine
5	the spot — nowhere left to use it	actually improving
6	the scarcity — they threw it away themselves	selling well

In all three, nothing was wrong with the product.

Which means making a better product stops none of them.

Chapter 4 · The Fad Was the Lifespan

★ "Barely used"

Search for something on a secondhand app and sometimes you get a strange screen.

Hundreds of the same object listed. Even the photo angles match.

The descriptions are nearly identical.

Barely used. Just taking up space, so clearing it out.

The sellers don't know each other. They bought at the same time and they're selling at the same time.

This thing wasn't thrown out because it broke.

Not one line complains about quality. They all say it works fine. It works fine and nobody uses it.

Strange — not long ago you couldn't get one.

What got cut?

★ The usual thought — fad products are cheap junk, so they go away

The idea is that it's a make-it-cheap, sell-it-fast, get-out business.

That's less than half right.

Plenty of fad products are well made. The dessert people queued for wasn't bad. The gadget everybody bought wasn't unusable.

And there's a bigger problem with this idea.

If cheapness were the cause, the answer would be easy. Make it well. If that answer were right, Part Two would be three pages long.

Well-made ones vanished too. So that isn't the reason.

Three cases.

★ The food fad — the queue was the product

For a while the same sign appeared on every street. Taiwanese castella did that, then sugar-glazed fruit skewers did.

The chain in the opening that hit five hundred shops in two years is the skewer one.

Both were selling the talk from Chapter 1.

Careful here. What people bought wasn't just the food.

The queue was half the value.

Having queued for it. Having a photo of that. That was part of the product.

Which gives this business a strange property:

The moment supply grows, half the product disappears.

Available everywhere means no queue, and no queue means no reason for the photo.

These foods have one more thing in common.

They aren't hard to make.

Buy the machine, or learn it in a few days. There's no way to block it. Trademark it and a similar

name opens next door.

So supply grows much faster than demand. And you find out you crossed the line only after you've crossed it.

★ The owning fad — worth nothing once everyone has one

There was a palm-sized electronic device that swept through kids — a toy where you raised a digital pet.

Different from food; you don't eat it and it's gone. It ended faster anyway.

The reason is in Chapter 2.

A thing on the fashion clock is no fun to own alone.

The rest of your class has to have one for it to be a conversation. When the conversation ends, the one in your hand loses value with it.

The object is unchanged and its value sits in other people's hands.

That creates an odd timetable:

The moment everyone has one is both the peak and the end. The best-selling month is the most dangerous month.

★ The heard fad — it shrinks as you use it

That song that played everywhere one summer.
The next year you barely hear it.

This is where the structure of the chapter is clearest.

Listening is using it up.

Wearing clothes doesn't reduce them; using a device leaves it there. Talk shrinks when used.

To someone hearing the same song for the twentieth time, it isn't the song it was the first time. The song didn't change. The newness ran out.

The first two were doing the same thing. The queue and the toy were being used up as they were used.

★ What got cut first

All three in one table.

	What was sold	What got cut first	The object
Queued-for dessert	food + the queue	supply grew, queue vanished	fine
Palm-sized toy	toy + the rest of the class	attention moved on	works
Song of that summer	song + newness	repetition wore it out	unchanged

Read the middle column down and you have the answer.

Talk shrinks when used. And using it is the same act as selling it.

That's the real problem with a fad product. The more you sell, the less you have to sell.

Which is the opposite of most making. Usually more volume means lower costs and a firmer position. Here, more volume means less remaining lifespan.

★ The real danger is somewhere else

Everyone knows the above. Nobody thinks fads last forever.

The real danger isn't that it ends. It's when it ends.

The curve doesn't look symmetrical.

Going up takes months. People find out one at a time.

Coming down isn't like that. It goes flat all at once.

The reason everyone loses interest simultaneously is simple. The signal that kills interest is also talk. "That's over now" spreads just as fast.

(No data was found that shows this asymmetry in numbers. This is an observation and it's labelled as one.)

So in this business the last one in loses everything.

Someone sees that it's selling best, decides to enter, and stands in front of a dead market a few months later when they finally open.

Losses in a fad business don't come from chasing a fad. They come from confirming the fad and then chasing it.

★ So should you not make fad products?

No. As Chapter 1 said, a fad gives you things nothing else gives you.

The problem isn't making one. It's **how much you stake on it.**

Treat a fad product like a fad product. Most people treat it **like something that will last.**

	Like a fad	Like it will last (dangerous)
Space	rent short	sign long
Making	have someone else make it	buy the equipment
Stock	order under	order comfortably
Payback	all of it within months	across years

The last row is the point.

A fad product's payback period has to be shorter than the fad.

Write that on paper at the start and you prevent most of the accidents. There's one reason people don't write it. While it's going well, nobody wants to think about the end.

★ And where the money goes

Money made from a fad goes one of two places.

One: making the same fad bigger. Chapter 6 is what that produces.

Two: buying a bridge.

One of the four named in Chapter 2 — Repeat, Shape, Patina, Handoff. They can only be bought while the fad is still alive.

Most of the things in Part Three made the second choice.

Spend fad money on the fad and it ends. Spend fad money on a position and it stays.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
What was selling	the object + the talk
Why it ended	talk shrinks when used, and selling is using
Was the product the problem	no — so better making doesn't stop it
Most dangerous moment	the best-selling month
Who loses most	the last one in, who waited for confirmation

Question

Answer

What to do

payback shorter than the fad; buy a bridge with the money

★ Where This Came From

Public sources cross-checked. No original filings were opened.

1. When Taiwanese castella shops and sugar-glazed fruit shops rose and fell, and the leading skewer chain's five-hundredth-shop announcement plus its shop count seven months later.
2. The release period and fad duration of the digital pet toy.

No data was found to support the asymmetry of the fad curve in numbers, so the text says so and leaves it as an observation.

★ Do This Today

Open a secondhand app. Search the name of one object in your house.

See how many are listed. Read three of the descriptions.

- Lots of "broken" or "upgrading" means it's still standing in its spot
- Lots of "barely used" means it was talk

Then one last question.

When people list the thing you made, what will they write?

If "I don't use it anymore" comes to mind, you haven't found the spot yet. Finding a spot can be done late. It's much cheaper while the fad is alive.

Chapter 5 · Nowhere Left to Use It

★ The drawer full of chargers

Every house has one drawer that is only cables and chargers.

Take them out and look at them one by one. About half, you won't know what they plugged into.

Here's the strange part.

Those devices weren't thrown out because they broke.

Most went into the drawer still working, and got binned one day later.

Different from the last chapter. Those things got boring when the fad ended.

These never got boring. There was just nowhere left to use them.

★ The usual thought — something better came along

The idea is they lost a competition.

Half right.

Some did lose. But look at what vanished and it doesn't add up.

Think of the dedicated satnav that stuck to a car windscreen. Being dedicated, it had a bigger screen and responded faster.

Torch, voice recorder, calculator, alarm clock, camera. Each of those did its own job better too.

They all lost anyway. They didn't lose — their spot disappeared.

There are three ways a spot disappears. They're completely different.

★ One • Getting swallowed

Satnav, music player, torch, voice recorder, calculator, camera.

That whole list got sucked into one place. The phone.

Notice something.

The swallower didn't win by being better.

The dedicated satnav had a bigger screen. The dedicated camera took better photos. The dedicated recorder captured better sound.

They lost anyway. One reason:

Whatever's already in your pocket wins.

People don't only count performance when choosing. They also count how many things they have to carry.

If one thing does the job, carrying a second one requires that second thing to be more than "a bit better." It has to be "can't do without it."

So the places where dedicated devices survive are fixed. Professional work. Situations where lives are at stake. Rough conditions.

There, "a bit better" becomes "can't do without it."

And this one comes with good news.

Getting swallowed is predictable.

Look at what people always carry. You can mostly guess what it will swallow next. What can be swallowed is what can fit inside as a part.

★ Two • A house built on a bridge

Some things sit exactly between two eras.

Needed briefly, between the old way and the completely different way.

That's a house built on a bridge.

It's useful while people are crossing the river. Once everyone's across, nobody needs the bridge.

These things have one trait in common.

They solved their era's problem extremely well.

Solving it well made them refined inside that problem, and when the problem disappeared they

went with it.

Being well made tied them in deeper.

The Chapter 2 sentence comes back:

Hold onto a method and you disappear with the method.

That object was holding onto "how music gets stored," not "listening to music."

And this one is **hard to see coming**. Whether a far bank will appear, and when, is difficult to know. Chapter 15 comes back to this problem.

★ Three • Nobody ever asked for it

The third is a different animal entirely.

Home television you watched in 3D glasses got pushed hard for several years. Manufacturers pushed together, it got the front spot in shops, broadcasts were prepared.

Then it quietly disappeared.

The stand-on personal transporter was similar. It came with talk of cities being redesigned around it.

These two differ from the first two in one decisive way.

They never had a spot to lose.

Swallowing and bridges are spots that existed and then went. This is a failed attempt to create a spot.

Which gives this chapter's most useful question:

Did people ask for this, or did we make it and show it to them?

If it's the second, there's no spot yet.

Making and showing isn't bad. Plenty of things nobody asked for changed the world.

But then the cost of creating the spot goes into the sums too. That cost is usually larger than the cost of making the thing.

And here's the truly dangerous part of this route.

Units sold is not evidence that people want it.

The sets sold. Very few people actually switched the feature on.

That's precisely the reason manufacturers gave when they dropped it. No demand. That's the

reason given by the people who had been pushing it, as they stopped.

Sold and used can be different numbers. That's the most important line in this chapter.

And this route is **the easiest one to see coming**. That nobody asked for it is a fact you already have on day one.

★ Swallowed by the same thing, and still here

Here's the counter-example, otherwise this chapter is just surrender.

The **phone swallowed the clock too**. Purely as a way of telling the time, the wristwatch was done.

Wristwatches did not disappear.

The reason is the core of this whole book.

The wristwatch stopped being a tool for telling the time. It became a thing you wear, and a thing you hand down.

It stepped off the field where function competes and sat somewhere else.

That's **changing clocks**, from Chapter 2. And it used two of the four bridges. **Shape and Handoff**.

What gets swallowed is a function, not an object. Only objects that are nothing but function go down with the function.

Turn that around and you get the work.

Count what your thing has besides function. If the answer is nothing, a better function isn't the answer.

Part Three is entirely about how to count.

★ The short version

Route	What happened	Can you see it coming	What to do
Swallowed	the always-carried thing ate the function	yes, easily	build value outside function
On a bridge	that step stopped being taken	hard	hold the need, not the method
Pushed	there was never a spot	easiest of all	ask whether anyone asked

All three share one thing.

The product was fine right to the end.

So quality stops none of them. Raising quality is especially dangerous in front of swallowing. The better you make it, the deeper it's tied to that function.

★ Where This Came From

Public sources cross-checked.

1. Home 3D television: when manufacturers dropped the feature from new models one after another, and that the reason they gave was lack of demand.
2. The stand-on personal transporter: when production ended, and that around then the product was a very small share of the company's revenue.

The claim that 3D came bundled into premium models could not be confirmed, so it was **cut from**

the text. Only the manufacturers' stated reason remains.

★ Do This Today

Pick one device that does exactly one job that you still use.

Write two things.

One, is there already something in your pocket that could do that job?

Two, if there is, why do you still use this device?

If the only answer to the second is "it does it better," that device is headed for the drawer eventually.

If the answer has something non-functional in it — it's worn to your hand, someone gave it to you,

you like the time you spend using it — that device has already changed spots.

What does the thing you make have besides function?

Chapter 6 · It Died by Growing

★ Three identical signs on one street

Within a two-minute walk there are three identical signs.

All three opened the same year. Two closed the next year. The one left has no customers.

The strange part isn't that they closed.

It's that three of them opened at the same time.

The three people who opened them don't know each other. All three looked at the same thing and reached the same conclusion. **This is what's working right now.**

All three were correct. It genuinely was working best at the time.

And all three went under. Which means there's a structure where a correct judgement ruins you.

★ The usual thought — if it's selling, expand

The idea is that there's no reason not to add supply where there's demand.

Half right.

Some businesses can expand. Some die when they do. And from outside they look identical.

Same revenue, same queue, same requests. The numbers match.

What splits them isn't the numbers.

It's what was being sold.

The Chapter 1 split changes the decision here.

★ Fad customers come in one national helping

The most important sentence in this chapter.

If need was selling, the customers are separate in every neighborhood.

Winter comes to every neighborhood; term starts in every neighborhood. Selling out in one doesn't reduce the next one's customers. So expanding expands.

If talk was selling, the customers are one national helping.

"That's the thing now" happens once, nationally. The number of people who respond to it is the

entire business.

Open ten shops and you divide that one helping by ten. You divide it and spend ten times as much.

	Need customers	Fad customers
Open 10 shops	10× the customers	same customers
Revenue per shop	unchanged	one tenth
Total cost	10×	10×
So	you grow	you die while growing

The same decision is growth on one side and suicide on the other.

The number from the opening is the last row of this table.

The chain announced its five-hundredth shop two years in, and seven months later there were four hundred and ninety.

What matters isn't that it fell. It's that nobody said stop while five hundred were being opened.

★ Contracts outlive fads

Crueller than the numbers is the time.

Confirm the fad, find a site, sign, fit it out, open.
Months at best.

The fad is still running during those months.

And as the last chapter showed, fads come down all at once.

Nobody knows where on the curve opening day lands. The contract is already signed.

Fads run for months. Contracts run for years.

That line is the heart of this chapter.

The reason people go under isn't bad trading. It's tying together two things with different lifespans.

Put a long thing on top of a short thing and the short one ends while the long one stays. And the long one costs money every month.

★ Two · Selling scarcity and then killing the scarcity

The second road to dying by growing happens in the product, not the shop.

There was a snack that was hard to get for a while. Finding one meant going to several shops, and having found one became something to talk about.

Question:

Did people buy the taste or the fact that it was hard to get?

Both, probably. And that's where the problem starts.

Being hard to get is an asset that disappears when you add supply.

But a strong sales signal makes you want to add supply. People who couldn't buy look like lost money.

So production goes up. And half the product disappears with it.

That snack did go through a long stretch of being sold out, then a new plant doubled supply, and its popularity declined afterwards.

Put that beside the queued—for dessert from the last chapter and it's the same structure. Queues and shortages both **need somebody who couldn't get one in order to have value.**

That gives an uncomfortable conclusion:

A business built on scarcity ends the moment it satisfies everyone.

And the person running it is tempted every single day, because the people who couldn't buy keep complaining.

This is the one case where giving customers what they ask for kills you.

Don't misread it. Nobody is telling you to withhold supply on purpose. The point is to know from day one that a business built on scarcity has

a short lifespan — and to build another position in the meantime.

★ Three • When somebody else carries the risk

This is the part to look at hardest.

When shops swarm in and vanish, people call it "bad judgement."

That explanation is usually wrong.

Look at how a franchise is built and the reason appears.

Head office's customer is not you. **It's the people who open the shops.** Head office revenue comes from franchise fees and selling supplies.

Which produces this:

Head office earns the moment a shop opens. If that shop closes two years later, head office doesn't give the money back.

The side carrying the risk and the side earning are different sides.

So there's no brake. Even when the fad is visibly fading, head office has no reason to slow down. Opening as many as possible before it dies is rational for head office.

The swarm isn't a mistake in judgement. It's a problem of arrangement. Whenever the decider isn't the risk-carrier, this is what happens.

This isn't only about franchises.

Work done with other people's money. Places where the reward comes first and the result comes later. Decisions made by people who'll be

somewhere else when the result lands. Same structure, same outcome.

Flip it and you get something you can use right now.

"Does the person telling me to do this lose anything if I go under?"

If not, what they're saying isn't information. It's a sales pitch.

★ So what do you do when it's going well

After all three of those, it feels hopeless. Expand and die; don't expand and miss it.

This is where this book's prescription first appears.

When it's going well, what you expand is bridges, not shops.

There are things you can only do while the fad is alive.

Bridge	What the fad lets you do
Repeat	build in a reason to buy another when it runs out
Shape	fix the form and color — people are looking right now
Patina	build in something that improves with use
Handoff	make it easy to give away and to pass down

All four get **much more expensive** once the fad **ends**. Fixing a shape while nobody's looking means nobody learns to recognize it.

The real value of a fad isn't the money. It's that people are looking at you for a while.

What to show them in that window is Part Three.

★ Three questions before expanding

One. Where do buyers come from?

From the neighborhood, they might be need customers. From far away, they're fad customers. Coming far means they heard about it.

Two. Is there a second visit?

Lots of first-timers and few returns means fad. This number is easy to count and costs nothing.

Three. Is the contract shorter than the expected lifespan?

Write down the expected lifespan even though you don't want to. Not writing it makes the default "forever," and that default ruins people.

★ The short version

How it died by growing	What got expanded	What disappeared
The swarm	shops	customers per shop — there was one national helping
Killing the scarcity	production	the people who couldn't buy — half the product
Split risk	franchises	the brake — the decider carried no risk

All three differ from the previous two chapters in one way.

In Chapters 4 and 5 something arrived from outside. In Chapter 6 nobody arrived. They did it to themselves.

All three are decisions made while things were going well. Which makes them the easiest to prevent, and the least prevented.

★ Where This Came From

Public sources cross-checked.

1. The dessert chain's five-hundredth-shop announcement and its shop count seven months later. Same item as the opening.
2. The long-out-of-stock snack: release period, how long the shortage ran, when expansion was decided, when the new plant doubled supply, and the decline in popularity afterwards.

Franchise head-office revenue structure is described only as the general shape visible in

disclosure filings. No specific company's fees or supply prices are given.

The three signs on one street is a scene, not a real case.

★ Do This Today

Think of something that's going well right now. It doesn't have to be yours. Something you're watching is fine.

Write three lines.

One, where do the buyers come from? Nearby or far?

Two, how many came a second time?

Three, when do you think this ends? Write a date.

The third is hard, and because it's hard nobody writes it.

Being wrong is fine. Writing it does something on its own.

Write down the day it ends and you also see what has to be done before then.

And that "what" is Part Three.

Part Three • The Ones That Stayed

★ These were fads too

Three chapters. The most important part of this book.

One thing to make clear first.

Everything in Part Three started where everything in Part Two started.

They were enormous fads. Everyone talked about them, queued for them, felt behind without one.

You could not tell them apart from the Part Two things. Nobody knew then which side would stay.

So Part Three asks one question:

They started in the same place. Where did they split?

★ One rule — traits Part Two also had don't count

Looking at survivors creates a problem. Too many reasons appear.

Good product. People loved it. Luck. The maker meant it. All true, all useless.

Every Part Two thing had all of those.

So there's a rule in this part:

A trait that Part Two also had does not count as a reason.

Apply it and very little survives. What survives is the actual answer.

★ The four bridges get used here

The four named in Chapter 2 come out now.

Chapter	Bridge built	What it asks
7	Patina · Handoff	does it improve with use? can it pass on?
8	Shape	is it recognized without explanation?
9	Repeat	does the moment come round and get bought again?

Two are in Chapter 7 for a reason.

Patina and Handoff are **landing bridges**. They decide where a thing sits once it comes down off the fad.

Shape and Repeat are **the bridges that hold the seat**.

★ And the limit

Part Three only looks at survivors.

Things built the same bridges and vanished anyway. **There must have been. They just aren't in the record.**

This book isn't saying "do this and you'll last." It's saying **"the ones that lasted turn out to have these things on them."**

Read it with that difference in mind.

Chapter 7 • It Changed Clocks

★ Basketball shoes nobody plays basketball in

Watch a game and the players' shoes change every year. Lighter, more ankle support, better cushioning.

Nobody on that court is wearing a shoe from twenty years ago.

Step outside the arena and it's a different story.

Plenty of people on the street wear shoes whose design hasn't changed in twenty or thirty years. Made for the court, and pushed off the court a long time ago.

The same shoe was retired in one place and stayed in another.

Strange. How does something that lost on performance live longer?

★ The usual thought — what lasted was a good product to begin with

Half right.

Go and read the original description of things that lasted and something odd happens.

The reason people use it now isn't written there.

Made for competition, worn on the street now.
Made for workshops, worn on stage now. Made
as a children's toy, bought mostly by adults now.

The use the maker wrote down and the use it has now are different.

So the accurate sentence is this:

What lasted wasn't a good product. It was a product that moved.

★ The maker isn't the one who moves it

The most important part of this chapter.

Moving spots doesn't get decided in a meeting room.

The users do it first.

The company didn't start people wearing sports shoes on the street. The factory didn't start people wearing work boots on stage.

Somewhere somebody used it outside its intended purpose, it spread, and the maker found out later.

That order almost never reverses.

Makers try to defend the original use. They built for it, they sold on it, they're the experts in that field.

So the maker's job sounds a little strange:

Not making it change clocks. Not blocking it from changing clocks.

There are many ways to block it and they all sound sensible.

"That isn't what it's for." "Using it that way voids the warranty." "It doesn't fit the brand."

All three are correct inside the company. And all three close the door on moving.

★ How to tell it's moving

Three signals.

One. You hear about use outside the intended purpose. "Can it also do this?" repeating means it already started.

Two. The kind of buyer changes. Different ages, different regions. Same revenue, different people — it's moving.

Three. People ask to have it repaired.

That's the strongest signal.

People don't repair things they could replace. They buy a new one. Asking for a repair means the thing became irreplaceable.

Repair requests usually get filed as a cost. They aren't a cost. They're a measurement.

★ First bridge · Patina — when time adds value

For most things time subtracts. New is the most expensive; use makes it cheaper.

Some things run the other way.

Leather, heavy cotton, cast iron, wood, instruments. Things where marks of use are value, not damage.

There are conditions. Not everything takes a patina.

One, it changes without breaking. Color fades, shape presses in, function stays. Plastic can't do this. It's fine and then it cracks.

Two, the change has to be yours. Mine and yours have to age differently. Aging identically is just wear.

Three, the beginning has to be a bit uncomfortable.

Here's the uncomfortable bit.

Things that take a patina usually start out stiff. Leather is hard. Cast iron is heavy and needs looking after.

Patina is a device that converts early discomfort into later attachment.

Which runs exactly against where markets go. Most improvement goes toward making the beginning easier.

Building in patina takes the nerve to make the start less comfortable.

And that decision reduces first-time sales. So most people don't. That's why so little survives into Part

Three.

★ Second bridge · Handoff — when it passes to the next person

There's an old block toy. What matters here isn't the toy. It's the way the pieces clutch.

That clutch system was patented more than sixty years ago. Blocks made then fit blocks made now.

To keep that one fact true, the company gave something up. It didn't switch to a better clutch system for sixty years.

A parent can pull out the box from their own childhood and hand it over. And buy a new box and mix them.

Handing down doesn't block buying new.

Handoff needs three things.

One, it doesn't break. Obvious enough that it gets forgotten.

Two, old and new work together.

This is decisive. Break compatibility and what was handed down becomes a memento with no use. A thing with no use gets thrown out soon after it's inherited.

Three, there's a reason to pass it on.

This is the hard one.

What gets handed down isn't the object. It's the time spent with the object.

So the thing needs somewhere for memory to attach. A place to write a name, a date, a mark left by something done together.

A thing memory can't attach to doesn't get passed on however tough it is. It sits in storage and gets binned.

★ The ones that moved, in a table

	From → To	Bridges built	Who moved it first
Sports shoes	court → street	Shape · Patina	users
Block toy	toy → a standard	Handoff · Shape	the old kids, now parents
Wristwatch	telling time → wearing	Shape · Handoff	users

Read the right column down and the answer appears again.

In all three, the maker didn't do the moving.

★ But changing clocks costs money

Look at this sharply. If changing clocks is so good, why doesn't everyone?

Because it loses money. Immediately.

One, the price can fall. What a professional pays, an everyday buyer won't.

Two, handed-down units aren't bought new.

Better Handoff, fewer new sales.

Three, keeping compatibility blocks change.

Fitting old pieces means giving up a better design.

Four, patina lengthens the replacement cycle.

Things used long sell less.

All four are true. So refusing to change clocks always has a plausible reason behind it.

Judged by this month, refusing is always correct.

The cost of changing clocks isn't measured by what you earn now. It's measured by whether you exist in ten years.

And ten years from now doesn't appear on this month's statement. That calculation is exactly where Parts Two and Three split.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
Who moves the spot	users. The maker finds out later
The maker's job	not making it move — not blocking it
How you notice	odd-use questions · buyer shift · repair requests
Patina needs	changes without breaking · ages individually · uncomfortable start

Question	Answer
Handoff needs	doesn't break · old and new work together · memory attaches
Why nobody does it	all four reduce what you earn right now

★ Where This Came From

Public sources cross-checked.

1. A trainer still sold in its old design: that it was originally for competition and is now everyday wear. When it moved could not be found, so it isn't stated.
2. The block toy: that the clutch system was patented more than sixty years ago and that pieces from then fit current products.

★ Do This Today

Pick one **thing** you've used for a long time in your house. Five years or more is enough.

Check two things.

One, was it better new, or is it better now?

If you answered **better now**, that thing has Patina on it. Write one line on what did it. The material? The shape? What you did with it?

Two, who could you hand this to?

If you can, write why it's worth handing on. If you can't, write what's missing. Broken? Doesn't fit? No memory on it?

Then the last question.

The thing you make — is a five-year-old one better than a new one?

Answering no is normal. Most things are like that. It just means that thing can only sell new, and in the new-thing competition something newer always arrives.

Chapter 8 • The Shape Became the Name

★ Take all the labels off

Put ten objects on a desk. Take every label off.

Most become unidentifiable. No maker, no idea if it's expensive.

A few you still recognize.

The curve of a bottle. The tread on a sole. One color on a wrapper. The angle of a handle.

The name is gone and the name is still there.

Strange. You erased the name. Why is the name still there?

★ The usual thought — a brand is a logo

The idea is that a good logo, shown enough, becomes a brand.

Half right.

It's missing the order in which people recognize things.

A logo has to be read. A shape is known before reading.

Recognizing letters means stopping your eyes and focusing. Shape gets processed before that. From far away, small, blurred — still known.

That difference has large consequences.

	Logo	Shape
To recognize	takes reading time	known before reading

	Logo	Shape
If you can't read the script	you can't	you can
In another country	needs translation	works as is
Far away, small	invisible	visible
On a shelf	you have to pick it up	you know it walking past

The last row is what this chapter is worth.

Shape works while you're spending nothing on advertising.

Sitting on the shelf is itself the advertisement. And that advertisement has no monthly bill.

Chapter 1 said a keeper costs almost nothing extra when it sells more. Shape is one of the devices that does that.

★ Three conditions for a shape becoming a name

Not every shape becomes a name. Three things are needed.

One. It has to be drawable.

This is a test you can actually run.

Hand people paper and ask them to draw it from memory. If the drawings come out similar, it has a shape. If not, it doesn't.

Drawable shapes share something. They're simple. Describing one takes less than a sentence.

Two. It can't change.

Shape accumulates. The same form has to be seen for a long time before it becomes a name.

Change it yearly and nothing accumulates. And the urge to change comes from inside.

The maker looks at their own object far more than anyone else. Looking a lot makes you sick of it. Being sick of it makes you want to change it.

The buyer sees it a few times a year. The maker sees it every day.

The one who got bored is the maker, not the buyer.

Three. It has to come from function.

The most important one and the most often missed.

Shapes that lasted mostly became that shape for a reason.

Tread patterns came from not slipping. The curve of a bottle came from gripping it with a wet hand. A handle's angle came from using less force.

A shape that came from function has a big advantage.

It needs no explanation. You look and you see why. And it **doesn't** age. If the function hasn't changed, the shape can't look odd.

A shape made as decoration ages with its era.

So there's a question to ask:

Did this shape come from function, or from the taste of its time?

Fix a shape that came from taste and it passes when the taste passes. The shape stops being an asset and becomes a dated look.

★ Shape isn't only shape

Widen the scope here. The core of shape isn't form. It's **not going through language**.

Which means five other things do the same job.

Sound. The sound of opening, of closing, the short note on switching on.

One color. Recognized by a single specific color. Color gets processed even faster than form.

Proportion. The ratio of the sides. The form can change and the ratio stays.

Texture. How it feels in the hand. This one doesn't need eyes at all.

Smell. The longest-lasting in memory and the least used.

None of the five needs reading. And none of the five can be peeled off like a logo.

A logo can be removed, covered, copied. Sound and texture can't.

Copying them means changing the object itself. At which point it isn't a cheap knockoff anymore.

★ What having a shape costs you

Time to be honest.

Shape is an asset and a shackle.

Fix a form and that form starts blocking things.

You could make it lighter, but the silhouette would change, so you can't. You could make it cheaper, but you'd lose that texture, so you can't. You found a better structure, but it wouldn't be recognizable, so you can't.

That list gets longer with time.

So companies with a strong shape are late to technical change. Not from incompetence. From protecting the asset.

You cannot have a shape without paying that price.

And there's one especially dangerous case.

When that shape was on the fashion clock to begin with.

Fix a form built from the taste of its era and the object passes when the taste passes. But it's already fixed, so it can't be changed.

The shape ties the object to its own decade.

★ So how do you change it — erase and test

There will come a time to change while keeping the shape. There's a method.

Keep the skeleton, change the flesh.

First you have to know **what the skeleton is**. Most makers don't know what people actually recognize. They guess.

The way to find out is simple. **Erase things one at a time.**

Show it with the color removed. Still recognized? Keep the form, remove the pattern. Still recognized? Keep only the proportion, remove everything else. Still recognized?

Whatever survives all the erasing is the skeleton.

Protect that one thing and everything else can change.

This work costs almost nothing. Paper and ten people. Not many places have done it.

Most do the opposite. They change everything slightly without knowing what the skeleton is. Recognition fades slowly, and one day nobody recognizes it and nobody can explain why.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
Why is shape strong	no language step. Known before reading
What it saves	advertising. Sitting there is the ad
Three conditions	drawable · unchanging · from function
Is shape only form	sound, color, proportion, texture, smell do the same

Question	Answer
What it costs	you can't change. Late to technical shifts
Most dangerous case	when the shape came from the taste of its era
How to change	find the skeleton by erasing , protect that one thing

Shape isn't a free asset. It's an asset you buy by selling your freedom to change.

★ Where This Came From

A bottle's own shape can be registered as a trademark. And the same company's attempt to register a **new, contour-less bottle shape** as a shape trademark was not accepted.

The registration years are not given. Sources differ on them. No year gets printed until the registry record itself is checked.

That tread patterns and bottle curves came from function is written only as a general explanation.

★ Do This Today

Get paper and a pencil. Don't look at the objects.

From memory, draw three things you like. They don't have to be good drawings. Recognizable is enough.

Then compare with the real ones.

- Anything that came out similar is an **object with a shape**
- If nothing came to mind at all, you know that one only by its logo

And one more.

If people drew the thing you make from memory,
what would appear?

If the answer is nothing, that's the job right now.
Shape doesn't cost much to make. The work is
fixing it and then not changing it for a long time.

Chapter 9 · The Season Sells It for You

★ Songs forgotten for eleven months that come back

Every December the same songs turn up again. In shops, in the street, everywhere.

They aren't new songs. They came out a long time ago.

Something odd here.

Normally a song gets played less over time. New songs arrive, people move on, it fades out quietly.

These songs get played *more* as time passes.

And the stranger part is the other eleven months.

For most of the year nobody plays them. They're completely forgotten. Forgotten and not dead.

★ The usual thought — seasonal goods only sell once a year, so they lose

Half right.

The selling window is short, that's true. There's something you get for it.

| The calendar does your advertising.

Normal products need continuous spending so people don't forget. Stop and they're forgotten, and forgotten is over.

Seasonal products don't need that. When the time comes, people remember on their own.

December brings carols to mind; cold weather brings thick coats to mind. Nobody has to tell them.

It's the same kind of asset as Shape in the last chapter. An asset maintained without a monthly payment.

★ There are only three ways to make someone buy again

Chapter 2 named Repeat, the first bridge. Here's the full version.

One. It runs out, so you buy more. Food, detergent, pencils, consumables. The most common and most reliable.

Two. The time comes round, so you buy again. Seasons, holidays, term starts, birthdays, regular servicing.

Three. Once at each stage of life. The doors from Chapter 3 are here.

Of the three, the second is the strongest. One reason:

Nobody has to remember.

Running out requires noticing that it ran out. Miss it and there's no purchase. Life stages arrive unpredictably and depend on the person.

The calendar announces the time. Buyer and seller both know in advance.

★ Four things a season gives you

One, the advertising window is fixed. You don't spend all year.

Two, being forgotten is survivable.

This is decisive.

Normal products are finished when they're forgotten. Seasonal products are allowed to be forgotten. They're better for it — being forgotten is what makes December welcome.

Three, you can plan. You roughly know when and how much will sell.

Four, new people arrive every year. The rotating customers from Chapter 3 attach automatically. Every year somebody hits that moment for the first time.

Put the four together and almost every condition for lasting is met. Which is why so many long-lived things are seasonal.

★ And three prices

Seasons are not free.

One. Miss a year and you wait a year.

Late preparation, not enough stock, an accident — and the whole year is gone.

Normal products can make it up next month. A seasonal product has no next month to make it up in.

So in this business the cost of a mistake is twelve times larger.

Two. No money comes in for eleven months.

This one actually kills people.

This is the classic case of the product succeeding and the business failing. Materials get bought in advance, staff have to stay, rent goes out monthly.

If you can't afford to wait out the season, don't sell a seasonal product.

That isn't a product problem. It's a money problem. And people rarely look at the money structure while choosing the product.

Three. Seasons can move.

The least visible risk.

A season looks like the need clock. Winter comes every year. **But what people *do* in that season is on a different clock.**

What gets exchanged at a holiday, what gets prepared for a new term, where people go in winter.

Those sit on the generation clock. They change over ten or twenty years.

The season is fixed. What people do in it isn't.

So what a seasonal business checks each year isn't the weather. It's whether people still do the same thing on that day.

★ Can you make a season?

Some seasons were made.

An example belonged here, but it was cut because it couldn't be confirmed from primary sources.

Which company did what and when is recorded differently depending on where you look.

Here are the conditions. Three.

One, there has to be a date. The date is the memory device. Without it there's no custom.

Two, there has to be someone you give to. Things done alone rarely become customs. A handing-over motion is what spreads it to the next person.

Three, a first-timer has to know exactly what to do. Complicated rules don't spread.

And an honest note:

Whoever makes a season cannot own it.

Once it's a custom, anyone can sell on that day. The company that made it sells, the copiers sell, the corner shop sells.

Making a season buys you a market, not a share of one.

So anyone trying to make a season has to take one more thing. The **default** position from Chapter 3.

The spot that comes to mind when someone asks "what do I get?" The season is shared. The default is one.

★ Building a cycle into something with no season

Most things have no season. There are four things you can still do, cheapest first.

One. Attach to a day that already exists. Much cheaper than making a new season. Find a day people already do something on and build a spot there.

Two. Design the rate at which it runs out. Too long and it's forgotten; too fast and it feels expensive.

Three. Let the object announce the replacement time. Color changes, a mark appears, wear

becomes visible. Not leaving it to human memory is the point.

Four. Make something that runs on a yearly unit. Something with a year on it, something only made that year, something you fill in year by year. Things people collect get a cycle for free.

All four cost design rather than money. And all four only work if you don't change them once made.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
What a season gives	the calendar does the advertising
Why "the time" is strongest	unlike running out, nobody has to remember

Question	Answer
If it's forgotten	seasonal products come back from being forgotten
Price one	miss a year, wait a year. Mistakes cost twelve times
Price two	eleven months of no money. Product succeeds, business fails
Price three	the season is fixed; what people do that day isn't

★ Do This Today

Open a calendar. Paper is good; a screen is fine.

Mark every day in the year when something has to be bought.

Holidays, birthdays, term starts, season changes, exams, anniversaries. More come out than you expect.

Then look at two things.

One, write what gets bought on each of those days. If it's the same thing every year, that's a keeper for you.

Two, are there months with nothing marked?

An empty month is a seat nobody has sat in yet.

And a last question.

What day on the calendar is the thing you make attached to?

If it isn't attached to any day, it means you have to manufacture a reason to think of it **every single time, with money.**

Part Four · The Late Arrivals

Part Two was the ones that vanished. Part Three was the ones that stayed.

Part Four is something else.

Things that failed once and succeeded later.

Here's what matters.

These were **not remade**. Not fixed, not relaunched.

The object stayed the same and only the result changed.

Which leaves one question.

If the object didn't change and the result did, the result wasn't inside the object.

So where was it?

Part Four splits that across three chapters.

Chapter	What changed
10	the outside — the world arrived late
11	where it got used — the use changed
12	who was looking — the old thing became new

All three say the same thing.

Not selling doesn't have to mean it was bad.

Used wrongly that sentence is genuinely dangerous, so the front of Chapter 10 is given

over entirely to that.

Chapter 10 · The World Arrived Late

★ A book nobody changed a word of starts getting borrowed

Library shelves hold books almost nobody takes out. Borrowed once every few years. Dust on them.

Then some of them start getting borrowed more from a certain year. A few years later they're always out and you have to reserve one.

Confirm one thing here.

Not one word of that book changed.

No revised edition, no rewrite by the author. The same sentences on the same paper.

Everything that changed was outside.

Odd, isn't it?

If the object didn't change and the value did, the value wasn't inside the object.

★ The usual thought — it was ahead of its time

The most common phrase for explaining why something didn't sell.

Half right. And it's the dangerous half.

Dangerous because it sounds like a compliment.

"Ahead of its time" means you weren't wrong, the world was slow. That's comfortable. It leaves nothing to fix.

But there's no diagnosis in it.

It wasn't ahead. It was standing in a spot that didn't exist yet. And spots that don't exist don't appear on their own.

Follow late arrivals through time and they share one thing.

The world didn't come by itself. Something brought it.

This chapter calls that something a **key**. There are three keys.

★ First key • It got cheap

Some things have the idea first and the materials later.

The design was finished long ago and what it needed was too expensive. Electricity was

expensive, or communication, or computation, or moving things.

The day that cost drops below a line, the thing suddenly becomes possible.

Note the property here.

Cost falls slowly and possibility arrives suddenly.

It gets a little cheaper each year, and the year it crosses the line, the number of people making it goes from one to a hundred.

So from outside it looks like "it suddenly became popular." It didn't. A line got crossed.

★ Second key • The place it sits came down

Sometimes the cost doesn't change at all.

What changes is where it sits.

What lived only in a laboratory comes down to an office. What lived in an office comes down to a house. What lived in a house comes down to a pocket.

Each step down multiplies the number of people who can try it.

This matters because the world is full of good things that didn't spread because nobody could get their hands on one.

Remember the doors from Chapter 3? Same thing. A narrow door keeps out good things just as well as bad ones.

★ Third key • People grew up with it as normal

The slowest and the most certain.

Some objects need explaining to anyone seeing them for the first time. Someone who grew up in a world containing them needs no explanation.

When explanation stops being needed, the cost collapses. All the money the seller spent on persuasion disappears.

The generation clock from Chapter 2 is back here.

The generation clock doesn't change the object. It changes the eyes looking at it.

Some things sit perfectly still and become easy one day.

★ So how do you tell ahead from wrong?

This is the most important part of the chapter.

Both look identical. Neither one sells. So everyone says "ahead of its time" and stops there.

There's one way to tell. Count two numbers.

One. How many people said it was good?

Two. How many people actually used it last month?

Put them side by side and the split appears.

What's ahead gets used by a few. What's wrong gets praised by many.

Read that again. It really is like that.

Lots of praise and zero users doesn't mean there's no spot. It means people are being polite.

Little praise, a few real users, and that few not shrinking — that's a spot that hasn't arrived yet.

At least it isn't shrinking. That's the signal.

★ Waiting isn't sitting still

"Wait for the world to catch up" is also dangerous.

Money goes out while you wait. So does time.

Same problem as Chapter 9. **You can't wait without something to wait on.**

So the two things a waiter actually does are these.

One. Stay alive small. Set up big and you can't wait. The money runs out before the key arrives.

Two. Watch for the key. Not waiting vaguely — deciding which key has to arrive.

Three lines:

What has to get cheap for this to work? How far down does it have to come for ten times as many people to try it? Who has to grow up for this to be normal?

If you can't write a single one of the three, it isn't ahead.

★ Where This Came From

Public sources cross-checked.

1. An old film set in a prison: that it took less at the box office than it cost to make, that it won none of the awards it was nominated for, that rental copies were distributed widely the following year and it became the top rental of that year, and that a broadcaster later acquired the rights and aired it repeatedly.

Not used

A novel that didn't sell in its day and later entered the curriculum belonged here, but the specific novel couldn't be identified, so no title is given.

The claim that things suddenly become possible below a cost line couldn't be backed by a specific case, so only the structure is described.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
Object unchanged, result changed	the value wasn't inside the object
Why "ahead of its time" is dangerous	it sounds like praise, so nothing needs fixing
Three keys	it got cheap · the place came down · people grew up with it
Ahead vs wrong	ahead is used by a few; wrong is praised by many

Question

Answer

To wait

stay alive small + **write down which key you're waiting for**

★ Do This Today

Pick something you're doing that **isn't working**.

A drawing, a video, something you made, a club — anything.

Count two numbers.

One, how many people said it was good.

Two, how many people actually used or watched it last month.

If the second is zero and the first is large, there's no missing spot. **People were being polite.**

Admitting that fast is cheaper.

If the second is small but not zero, and **not smaller than last month**, that's a different story. The key hasn't arrived.

Then write three lines.

What has to get cheap for this to work? How far down does it have to come for ten times as many people to try it? Who has to grow up for this to be normal?

If you can't write a single one, **stop using the phrase "ahead of its time"** as of today.

Chapter 11 · It Survived by Changing What It Was For

★ How a failure survived twelve years

A company set out to make a very strong adhesive. What came out was the opposite. An adhesive that barely sticks.

It sticks, but weakly. Peel it and it comes away. It leaves no mark.

Measured against the goal, a complete failure.

Normally it ends there. It didn't.

The person who made it didn't throw it away. He walked around the company asking. "Is there anything this is good for?"

He asked for years and the answer kept being no.

Then another researcher thought of something.

The paper markers in his hymn book kept falling out.

An adhesive that peels off and leaves no mark.

That was exactly the answer to that problem.

From discovery to a proper product took **twelve years.**

There's probably one on your desk right now.

★ The usual thought — throw failures away

Half right.

Most failures should be thrown away. Otherwise the storeroom fills with rubbish.

There's one kind of failure you don't throw away.

When the goal was missed and one strange property appeared that you weren't aiming for.

The weak adhesive is that. "Weak" was a defect, and in the right spot it was a feature.

Which gives this chapter's sentence:

Defect or feature isn't decided by the object. It's decided by the spot.

★ Four shapes of a defect becoming a feature

One. When weak is good. Too weak to use, until the spot requires peeling.

Two. When short-lived is good. Disappearing fast is a flaw, until the spot requires leaving nothing behind.

Three. When ugly is good. Not finished smoothly, until the spot wants the look of a human hand — then the price goes up.

Four. When stiff and crude is good. Not made comfortable, until the spot is rough use — then it outlasts everything.

All four have the same structure. The property didn't change. The verdict flipped.

★ Sometimes the users find the spot first

Sometimes the maker doesn't find it and the users do.

There was a cheap work boot. Air in the sole meant less pain from standing all day. So at first it was worn by postal workers and factory workers.

It had nothing to do with fashion.

Then group after group wore it. Musicians wore it, then another group, then another.

Nobody had built it to sell that way.

There's something to learn here.

| If it's being used somewhere odd, that's the hint.

The most common mistake sellers make is this:

"That isn't what our product is for."

Saying that throws away the next ten years.

★ So what do you watch — three things

One. Something people do that nobody told them to.

If people use it in a way that isn't in the instructions, watch that. One person is a quirk. Several people arriving at it separately is a spot.

Two. Whether they're putting up with inconvenience.

If it doesn't quite fit and they use it that way anyway, the signal is strong. Putting up with inconvenience means there's no substitute.

Three. Whether they're buying something else alongside it.

If people buy extra things to make your thing work, that's the real spot.

★ But changing the use changes the customers

Not just good news. Here's the price.

When the use changes, the original customers often don't stay.

When a work boot becomes a fashionable boot, the person who wore it for work leaves — price up, or hard to find.

So that company lost its old business and gained a new one. Not added. Swapped.

Count it as "customers went up" without noticing and you get a surprise later.

And one more.

The new arrivals might be on the fashion clock, while the original customers were on the need clock.

Think back to Chapter 2. Change the clock and you change the lifespan.

★ Where This Came From

Public sources cross-checked.

1. The weak adhesive: that it came out of an attempt at a strong one, that its maker spent years looking for a use inside the company, that another researcher thought of a use from the hymn-book marker problem, and that it took **twelve years from discovery** to reach a full release after test marketing. The maker's published company history carries this.
2. The air-cushioned boot: that it began as a cheap work boot for postal and factory workers, and that various subcultures wore it afterwards.

Not used

A military processed food that became an everyday dish in one region belonged here, but the

country and product couldn't be confirmed, so the names were cut. Only the structure is written.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
Throw every failure away?	keep the one that grew a strange property
Defect or feature	the object doesn't decide. The spot decides
What to watch	uninstructed use · tolerated inconvenience · what's bought alongside
The most dangerous sentence	"That isn't what it's for"
The price	changing the use swaps your customers

★ Do This Today

Find three objects in your room or bag that you're using for something other than what they're for.

There definitely are some. Everyone has some.

Write one line on each.

Why did this fit this spot?

Then the real part.

Check whether the three have something in common.

Cheap? Right size? Doesn't matter if it breaks?
Stiff? Light?

If one shared property appears, that's what you actually value in objects.

People mostly don't know what they choose on.
The things you're using wrongly will tell you.

Words can be dressed up. How you're already
using something can't.

Chapter 12 · When an Old Thing Suddenly Becomes New

★ A thirty-seven-year-old song went to number one

An old song was used in one season of a drama. It played over an important scene, and that scene travelled.

Then this happened.

The song went to number one on that country's official chart.

The song had first been released thirty-seven years earlier.

And one more thing. The same singer's previous number one had been **forty-four years earlier**.
Reportedly the longest gap between number ones in that chart's history.

One thing to confirm:

Most of the people who put that song at number one weren't born when it came out.

So to them it wasn't an old song.

It was a song they were hearing for the first time.

★ The usual thought — old and new are fixed
Half right.

The date it was made doesn't change. True.

But whether it's new to the listener isn't decided by the date.

The difference between old and new isn't in the object. It's in the age of the person looking.

Read that once more.

You've had this happen. Something you loved as new turned out to be from a long time ago.

A song, some clothes, a game. Didn't that feel slightly strange?

That feeling is the whole chapter.

It wasn't new to the world. It was new to you.

★ Why this keeps happening more

Old things used to be kept in old places. You had to go and find them, so people who didn't look never knew.

Not anymore.

Things in a recommendation feed don't have dates on them.

Side by side on a screen, last year's and forty years ago's look the same. Same font size, same thumbnail.

So age is invisible.

When age is invisible, old things stand in the same queue as new ones.

Once an old thing stands in the same queue as new ones, all that's left is whether it's good.

And in that queue the old thing has an advantage. It survived long enough to get there, so it's already been filtered once.

★ Not everything gets rediscovered

Time to be honest.

Being discovered is luck. Genuinely luck.

Which scene gets which song, whether that scene travels — nobody decides that. Not even the maker.

So "let's make it get discovered" is not a plan.

But being in a state where you can ride it when luck arrives can be built. That's an entirely different thing.

Riding the wave needs three things.

One. It has to still exist.

The most basic and the most missed. Gone means undiscoverable. Dead company, discontinued product, deleted video.

Waves only come to things that are still there.

Two. It has to be findable.

Searching the name has to return it. Someone watches the scene, thinks "what's that song," and it has to come up in three seconds.

If it doesn't, people move on. Everyone is busy.

Three. It has to be gettable immediately.

Found and unbuyable ends it there. Cooling off takes less than a day.

One line:

Even when a wave comes: gone, unfindable, or unbuyable means it passes by.

Which is why only things that stayed a long time ride that wave.

Staying looks dull. Staying is how you buy the ticket.

★ And after the wave passes

Know this too.

Waves pass. Weeks, a few months at most.

Afterwards it's one of three things.

One. Back to where it was. The most common.

Two. It settles slightly higher. Some of the new arrivals stay.

Three. It becomes a completely different thing.
Rare.

Aim at the second.

Assume everyone who came on the wave will stay and you'll scale up to that number, and Chapter 6 happens. You die by growing.

A wave doesn't give you customers. It gives you a chance. Keeping them is what you do next.

★ Where This Came From

Public sources cross-checked.

1. That a long-ago song used in one season of a drama went to number one on that country's official chart, that this was **thirty-seven years** after release, and that the gap from the same singer's previous number one was **forty-four years**, reportedly the longest in that chart's history.

Not used

Why that particular song was the one rediscovered isn't written. There's no way to count how many songs met the same conditions and weren't. Without that denominator you can't state a cause.

The claim that old customers left after the wave passed couldn't be confirmed with a case, so only the structure is written.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
Old vs new	the object doesn't decide. The viewer's age does
Why more of this now	screens don't print dates
Is discovery a plan	no. It's luck
What you can do	still exist · be findable · be buyable

Question

Answer

After the wave

aim to **settle slightly higher**

★ Do This Today

Write down five things you like. Songs, films, games, objects — anything.

Now look up **when each one came out.**

How many of the five came out before you were born?

If none did, you're only looking at what's being made now. That means standing only on the fashion clock from Chapter 2.

If two or more did, you're already choosing **filtered** things.

And one last question.

Take the oldest one and ask:

Why is this still here?

Write the answer down. What you build in Part Five should look like that answer.

Part Five • So What Do You Make

Four parts so far.

What vanished, what stayed, why things arrive late. All of it about things other people made.

Part Five is about you.

Four chapters, and they run in order.

Chapter	What it does
13	Choosing what to make — look at something other than the charts
14	Making people move now

Chapter	What it does
15	The order you build the bridges in
16	Why you aren't late

Chapter 13 chooses, 14 launches, 15 lands it.

And 16 says the one thing this whole book has been trying to say.

One note first.

Part Five is not telling you to start a business.

It doesn't matter what you make. A video, a drawing, a club, the way you study — it works the same.



These four chapters aren't about "what do I sell."
They're about "why would what I do still be here."

Chapter 13 · How to See What's Stuck

★ Everyone is looking at the same screen

How do you find out what's popular right now?

You check a chart, or the recommendations, or what other people are doing.

There's a problem.

You aren't the only one looking at that. Everyone is.

Look at the same thing and find out the same thing, and the judgement you reach is the same judgement everyone else reached.

The same judgement doesn't put you in front.
Obviously.

★ The usual thought — read trends well and
you're fine

Half right.

Reading is necessary. What you read is everything.

This chapter is two lists. Three not to look at, and
three to look at.

★ Three not to look at

One. Charts.

A chart shows you what sold last month. It isn't a
tool for looking forward. It's a tool for looking
back.

Plus the problem above: everyone sees the same one.

Two. Anything that already has a name.

Something having a name means a lot of people already noticed it. It means it was discussed enough times for a name to stick.

The moment it has a name is already late.

Three. What somebody else already succeeded at.

Look at a success and you see the conditions but not the cause.

Nobody records how many places had the same conditions and failed. So looking only at successes teaches you the same wrong thing every time.

All three share one trait.

All three already happened.

★ Three to look at

One. What people are solving badly.

This is the most useful tool in the chapter.
Genuinely.

People don't sit in discomfort. **They solve it.** And with nothing proper available, they solve it **badly.**

Tape holding something together. Two things used together. A step order that's clearly been rearranged. Someone else's object used for something it isn't for.

Where there's a bad fix, there is always an empty seat.

Look around a classroom. There is an enormous amount of this.

And this signal differs from a chart in the decisive way. It's happening in front of you right now.

Two. Something that just got cheap.

The first key from Chapter 10.

You have to be holding a list of what has to get cheap for what to work. No list and the price falls right past you.

Three. Somewhere a rule changed.

School rules, laws, terms of service — something being allowed or banned creates or destroys a spot.

This one has a peculiar feature. It's announced in advance. You're reading, not predicting.

★ What reading actually means

Put together:

Reading trends is not guessing what will take off.

It's seeing what's stuck right now.

Why that difference matters:

Guessing what takes off requires **being faster than everyone else**. The fast side is the side with money and information. That isn't you.

Seeing what's stuck requires no speed. **You just look closely.**

And looking closely is free.

That sentence runs all the way to Chapter 16.

★ But not everything stuck is an opportunity

Cold water here.

Where something is stuck and nobody has fixed it, there's usually a **reason**.

One. It isn't worth money. Only ten people are bothered.

Two. Nobody can fix it. It's genuinely hard.

Three. Fixing it breaks something else. Helping one side hurts another.

So once you've found an empty seat, ask one more line.

Why hasn't this been fixed yet?

If the answer is "nobody noticed," it's a good seat.
If it's "nobody can," you need to check whether

you can. If it's "it doesn't pay," leaving it alone is usually right.

Skip this question and you walk straight into a place a hundred people already tried and failed.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
Charts	last month's. Everyone sees the same one
Once it has a name	already late
Success stories	you see conditions, not causes
The best signal	what people are solving badly
What reading means	not guessing — seeing what's stuck
Found an empty seat	why hasn't this been fixed? — one more line

★ Do This Today

Over one day, **find and write down five bad fixes.**

Home, classroom, the walk there, the canteen, the club room. Anywhere.

Something held on with tape. Something that needs two things used together. Something where the order has to be done strangely. Something being used for what it isn't for.

Five will turn up. If they don't, you haven't looked closely yet.

Then pick one and ask:

Why has nobody made this properly yet?

If the answer comes immediately, you already know the reason. If it doesn't, **watch that one for a few more days.**

That seat is the material for the rest of Part Five.

Chapter 14 · Making a Reason to Act Now

★ It's good and nobody moves

You've had this happen.

You made something properly and showed people.
They all say it's good. They seem to mean it.

And nothing happens.

Nobody buys it, nobody does it, nobody comes
back.

It feels strange. They didn't say they disliked it.

One reason:

Good isn't a reason to buy.

Good is good. Moving today is a separate problem.

★ The usual thought — make it better and they'll buy

Half right.

If it's bad enough, obviously nobody buys. True.

But making a good thing better does not make anyone move today.

Because what people think is this:

"Nice. I'll do that later."

Later doesn't arrive. That's the whole thing.

So what you need isn't a reason it's good. It's a reason it's now.

★ There are only five reasons to move now

Only five. They've been counted.

One. A deadline. You can only do it until a date.

Two. Scarcity. You might not get one.

Three. A season. Now is the time.

Four. Being seen. Others are looking. Not having it now means not showing it now.

Five. Others already did. Not doing it leaves you behind.

Line them up and one thing is obvious.

All five are about time.

None of them is about how good the thing is.

Which gives this chapter's sentence:

Launching isn't showing off a product. It's manufacturing time.

★ Four of the five wear out

Criticism now, or this chapter is dangerous.

Chapter 4 said talk shrinks when used. These devices shrink when used too.

A deadline every time isn't a deadline. Scarcity every time isn't scarcity.

Use one on the same person twice and it's half as strong. The third time it's **negative**.

They feel tricked. And feeling tricked doesn't wear off.

Of the five, one doesn't wear out.

The season.

Why is in Chapter 9. The calendar remakes it every year. December arrives again whether you do anything or not.

Device	Cost to make	Wears out?	How often usable
Deadline	cheap	fast	a few times
Scarcity	medium — must be real	yes	rarely
Season	free. The calendar gives it	no	forever
Being seen	costs design	no	continuous ly
Others did	hardest at the start	no	continuous ly

The order falls out of the table.

Season, being seen, and others did are devices you can keep using. Deadline and scarcity are cards you play once each.

And most people do it backwards. They keep using deadlines and scarcity, and never build a season.

Because the easy ones are easy.

★ A warning on scarcity

Scarcity needs special care.

Its value comes from the fact that somebody couldn't get one. That is an asset that disappears if you add supply.

Launching on scarcity and then wanting to make more is natural — there's a queue of people wanting to buy.

Nobody is saying don't make that decision. **Just know it's a decision to sell your own asset.**

Same place as Chapter 7.

★ **Write two lines before you launch**

The most practical part of the chapter.

Write two lines before launching and you avoid most accidents.

Line one.

Why does this have to happen today rather than next month?

The answer has to be one of the five. If you answered "because it's good," you aren't ready.

Line two.

Can I use that answer again next year?

If you can, you built a device that keeps working.
If you can't, you played a card.

Playing a card isn't wrong. You just have to be counting how many you have left.

★ And after it takes off is the real thing

Remember Chapter 6? Dying by growing.

Launching only brings people in. Keeping them is a completely different job.

Which is why Chapter 15 sits directly after this one.

Do 14 without 15 and you become a Part Two story.

Everything that went off loudly once and disappeared split right there.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
Good, and nobody moves	good isn't a reason for today
How many reasons	five. All of them about time
The one that doesn't wear out	the season. The calendar remakes it
Most common mistake	only ever using deadlines and scarcity

Question	Answer
Scarcity	an asset that dies if you add supply
After launch	Chapter 15. Skip it and you're Part Two

★ Do This Today

Think of one thing you're making now.

A video, a drawing, a club sign-up — doesn't matter.

Ask it one line.

Why does this have to be seen today rather than next month?

Write the answer. Then tag which of the five it is.

Deadline · Scarcity · Season · Being seen · Others did.

If it's none of the five, you're persuading **purely on good.**

Then one more line.

Can I use this answer next year?

If not, use it knowing you're spending a card.

And last:

Which of the five have you never once used?

For most people it's **the season.** Which is also the cheapest and the longest-lasting.

Chapter 15 · The Order You Build the Four Bridges In

★ You can't build four at once

Chapter 2 named the four bridges. Part Three looked at them one at a time.

Repeat · Shape · Patina · Handoff.

Bridge	What it asks
Repeat	is there a reason to buy again?
Shape	recognized with the name covered?
Patina	better with use?
Handoff	can it pass to someone else?

One question left.

Which one first?

You can't build four at once. Not enough money or time. So there has to be an order, and the order isn't arbitrary.

★ The usual thought — start with the impressive one

Half right.

The impressive one is usually **Shape**. The one people recognize on sight. So everyone starts there.

Start with Shape and this happens a lot:

People recognize it and there's no reason to buy again.

You make one good-looking thing and it's over.
That's exactly where Part Two starts.

The order has to be the reverse of the order things
collapse in, not the order of impressiveness.

★ The order

First, Repeat.

Simple reason:

Without Repeat there's no time to build the other
three.

Shape takes time to become known. Patina
literally requires time to pass. Handoff requires
being around long enough for someone to hand it
to.

All three eat time, and Repeat is what buys that time.

Chapter 9 said "the time coming round" is the strongest kind. That pays off here.

Second, Shape.

Once there's Repeat, the next job is **not being confusing**.

If they come back to buy and don't know which one to buy, Repeat doesn't accumulate. Shape solves that.

And Shape has the good property from Chapter 8. It's maintained with no monthly payment.

Third, Patina.

From here it takes time. It can't be pulled forward.

So it's third, and it has to be designed on day one. Build it without long use in mind and you can't add it later.

Fourth, Handoff.

The slowest. Enough has to pile up to be worth passing on.

Its conditions also have to be built in advance. It has to be made so it *can* pass to someone, or it never will.

So:

Build order: Repeat → Shape → Patina →
Handoff. Design order: all four on day one.

★ When to build — before it takes off

The most important sentence in the chapter.

Build after it takes off and it costs more for three reasons.

One. People have already decided what the thing is. Change it later and it becomes a different thing.

Two. When it's going well you can't make a decision that reduces anything.

That's the real reason. More on it below.

Three. Big things can't change. The more that's fixed, the more changing costs.

So Chapters 14 and 15 have to happen together. Think about landing after you've taken off and it's already late.

★ Why nobody does it

The part of this book that has to be most honest.

All four bridges reduce what you earn right now.

Repeat means not selling big once. Shape means not changing with fashion. Patina means long use and fewer sales. Handoff means the person who inherited it doesn't buy one.

Judged by this month, not building is always correct.

Bridges aren't expensive. The decision is hard because they reduce what you earn now.

That sentence is the line between Part Two and Part Three.

The things that vanished didn't vanish from lack of money. They vanished because this month was correct every time.

And it's the only genuinely hard thing in this book. The rest is just knowing.

★ If you can't build all four

Something realistic.

Building all four is hard. Most don't.

Two is enough to last a long time.

The character changes with the combination.

The two built	What you get
Repeat + Shape	steady sales. The safest
Repeat + Patina	users rarely leave
Shape + Handoff	talked about for a long time. Money comes slowly
Patina + Handoff	the object survives. The slowest

One bridge is precarious. If that one wobbles it's over.

So the target isn't four. It's two.

★ Check yourself

Four lines, yes or no.

One. Does someone who liked this have a reason to buy again? (Repeat)

Two. Cover the name — is it recognizable?
(Shape)

Three. Is a year-old one better than a new one?
(Patina)

Four. Can you hand this to someone and have it still work? (Handoff)

Zero yeses means no bridges yet. Then however well it's going, you're standing on the Part Two side.

One yes means building a second one is this year's work.

Two or more is genuinely solid. And not letting go of those two is the whole of the work ahead.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
The order	Repeat → Shape → Patina → Handoff
Why Repeat first	it buys the time to build the other three
When to build	before takeoff. Together with Chapter 14

Question	Answer
Why nobody does	all four reduce what you earn now
Part Two vs Part Three	whether this month won every time
How many needed	two is solid

★ Do This Today

Answer the four lines above about something you're making.

Yes or no only. Don't write essays.

Then **pick one of the noes**.

If you can't decide which, **pick Repeat**. That's the order.

Then write one last line.

| If I build this bridge, what goes down?

If you can write that line, you've read this book properly.

If **nothing goes down**, it isn't a bridge. There is no bridge in the world you can build while giving up nothing.

Chapter 16 · A Game You Can Start Late

★ How old are the things in this book

Think back over what you've seen.

A shop in the same spot for over a thousand years.
A work boot over a hundred years old. A plastic
block system around seventy. A song that reached
number one thirty-seven years on. A failure that
took twelve years to become a product.

One thing in common.

Not one of them went fast.

And something more important.

Not one of them set out to last.

They all just never went away.

★ There are two games

This whole book in two sentences.

There are two games in the world.

One. The guessing game.

Work out what's about to take off and get on it.

In fast, out fast.

Two. The staying game.

Don't disappear. Be there whenever people look.

They're completely different games. They're won differently.

The guessing game is won by whoever's fastest.

The staying game is won by whoever didn't quit.

Here's what you need to know.

The guessing game is already decided at the starting line.

The side with money, faster information, more contacts wins. You're at a disadvantage there. That isn't comfort, it's fact.

The staying game isn't like that.

The difference between someone who started today and someone who started three years ago is three years. And three years can be closed.

★ The usual thought — whoever started early has the advantage

Half right.

In the guessing game, true.

In the staying game, false.

The reason is slightly funny, and real.

Whoever started first is also at zero if they quit.

Score in the staying game isn't "how early did you start." It's "are you still doing it."

So in this game people keep dropping out. Every year there are fewer people ahead of you.

It's a game where standing still moves you up the rankings.

★ Why nobody's over here

If the staying game is such an advantage, why isn't everyone playing it?

Because it's boring.

Really. That's the reason.

The guessing game gives results fast. A few months and you know. And when you win, it shows.

In the staying game **nothing happens for years.**
Nobody notices, and there's no score at halftime.

Competition is thin here not because it's hard to enter but because it's boring.

That's good news. You can't enter a place that's empty because it's hard. You can enter a place that's empty because it's dull.

Putting up with it is free.

★ Three reasons starting late is an advantage

One. The staying game counts from today.

Starting late isn't a loss. And whoever started early is at zero if they quit.

Two. Someone starting late can start small.

Chapter 6. The lower your monthly outgoings, the longer you last.

And having little right now is an advantage here.

Nothing to protect, no scale to maintain, no money to pay back. Nothing is set up big, so nothing collapses.

Remember how the people ahead of you died in Chapter 6? **They died by growing.** You aren't big yet.

Three. You read Part Two.

You start **knowing** how the people ahead of you fell.

You won't mistake talk for need, you won't sign longer than the fad, and when it's going well you can add bridges instead of shops.

This is information the people ahead of you could not buy.

When they were living it, it hadn't happened yet.

★ And when people love something deeply, they talk

One more thing.

Something a few people love deeply often lasts longer than something a lot of people bought.

Simple reason.

Deep liking makes people talk. Nobody has to ask them to.

Without being paid, they tell a friend, lend it,
invite someone along.

That's how the rotating customers from Chapter 3
appear. And it costs no advertising.

Honestly though: **depth isn't money**. Ten people
who love it deeply are ten people.

There's still an order. Going wide means going
deep first. It rarely works the other way.

★ So one question changes

The last thing this book has to say.

The usual question is this:

What's going to take off?

Not a bad question, but a bad question for you.

It's a question the fast side wins.

This book asks a different one:

What isn't going to go away?

You can answer that by looking closely. And looking closely is free.

One more thing, and it's for you specifically.

What's popular in your classroom right now will not matter in ten years. What you keep finding yourself thinking about will.

Fads pass. That part is certain.

But the thing you keep looking at, year after year, the thing nobody else pays much attention to and you keep noticing —

that's where the staying game starts.

★ An advantage isn't the same as easy

Last honest note. Leaving it out would be a lie.

In the staying game the prize comes late.

And usually it doesn't come.

You can do ten years and have nothing happen.

That is the normal result of this game. Not failure.

Normal.

So here's the one thing to confirm at the end.

Why those ten years aren't wasted.

Chapter 12 said riding a wave needs three things:

exist, be findable, be gettable.

And Chapter 15's four bridges: bought again,
recognized, better with use, passable on.

Look at those seven.

Every one of them pays off with no wave at all.

Being easy to find is just good. Getting better with
use is just good. Wave or no wave.

Preparing for a wave and simply being in good
shape are the same thing, so no wave means
nothing was wasted.

That's the whole of what this book can promise.

And it's a promise that can be kept.

★ The short version

Question	Answer
Two games	guessing · staying
How they're won	fastest · whoever didn't quit
Why it's empty	not hard — boring
Why late is fine	counts from today · small, so it doesn't collapse · you read Part Two
The question to change	what will take off → what won't go away
The prize	usually doesn't come. The preparation is good shape anyway

★ Do This Today

Write one line on paper.

Will I still be doing this in ten years?

Put something you're doing now into it.

If yes, that one thing is your staying game. You don't need to look elsewhere.

If no, that's fine. It's no for most people. Then finding the thing you'd still be doing is the work ahead.

How to find it is Chapter 13. Not the charts — look at what you keep finding yourself noticing.

And remember one thing.

You cannot start this game too late.

It isn't a game where whoever started late loses. It's a game where whoever quit loses.

So starting today is fine. You're one day behind whoever started yesterday.

Closing — What Will Still Be in Your Hands in Ten Years

★ Back to five hundred and a thousand years

The opening had two shops.

One that hit five hundred in two years and shrank seven months later. One that has sold grilled rice cakes, one item, for a thousand years.

Sixteen chapters on, what looks different?

The five hundred was on the fashion clock.

When the clock stops, it stops with it. The more shops, the bigger the stop. Exactly Chapter 6. It died by growing.

The thousand years was on the need clock.

There's a shrine in front, people come to pray every year, and every year they're different people. That's the spot from Chapter 3. **Where customers are new every year.**

And that shop didn't expand. No department stores, no new items, no branches.

That wasn't laziness.

It stayed small enough to survive a quiet thousand years.

★ One thing this book never said

Something deliberately left unsaid.

This book doesn't decide which side you want to be on.

It never said earning big and finishing is bad. It never said earning small for a long time is right.

Both are valid choices, and **both cost something**.

- Go big and it's fast, and **you don't know when it ends**
- Go long and it doesn't go out, and **the prize comes late or never**

Which one you pick depends on your situation and your temperament.

Choosing without knowing and choosing while knowing are different.

The people who opened those five hundred shops mostly worked hard. What was missing wasn't effort. It was knowing which clock they were on.

★ Sixteen chapters in one sentence

Don't try to guess what will take off. Find what won't go away, sit on it, and spend your time on not disappearing.

None of the three needs special talent.

Guessing needs **faster information than everyone else**. You lose that one. Finding what won't go needs **looking closely**. That one is free. And not disappearing needs **not quitting**.

Which is why the last chapter is called "A Game You Can Start Late."

★ But doing something for a long time is the hard part

Honestly: the third is the hardest.

Tell someone to wait ten years and nobody can. Waiting shaves a little off a person every day.

So Chapter 16 said it differently.

It isn't waiting through for a wave. It's being in a state where you don't need one.

The thousand-year shop didn't wait a thousand years.

It grilled rice cakes every day. And each day ran itself.

Build a state that runs itself, even a small one, and staying stops being endurance. It becomes just living.

How to build that state is Parts Three and Five.

★ One last thing to do

Before you close the book, just this.

Find the oldest object in your house.

It doesn't have to be yours. Your parents'. Your grandmother's.

A bowl, a pair of scissors, a blanket, a strange box nobody has thrown out.

Hold it and ask one line.

Why is this still here?

An answer will come. Usually one of these:

- something makes you use it again (Repeat)
- you know it by looking (Shape)
- long use made it better (Patina)
- it was handed down (Handoff)

This book was about those four.

And the object in your hand right now has most likely never once been famous.

Never on a chart. Nobody talked about it.

It just didn't go away.

★ And one more

The last question. This one really is the last.

What will still be in my hands in ten years?

Ask it about work, not only objects.

Something you'd still be doing in ten years.

Something nobody credits you for and you keep noticing anyway.

If you have one, do that.

If you don't, that's fine. You're still looking. And the time it takes to look isn't a loss.

The staying game counts from today.

★ What was confirmed while writing this

One last thing to put down.

Looking at a lot of long-lived things while writing this, one thing was common to them.

Almost none of them planned to last.

The thousand-year shop didn't plan a thousand years. The failure became a product by accident twelve years later. The thirty-seven-year-old song had a drama scene.

None of it was planned.



Old things weren't born special. They just never
grew a reason to disappear.

So what you have to do today isn't make
something great.

It's removing reasons to disappear, one at a time.

You can start that today.

How This Was Made — What Was Confirmed and What Wasn't Used

★ Why print this

Books don't usually have this section.

But this one kept saying "if it couldn't be confirmed, it isn't in here." You should be able to check whether that's true.

So three things go here.

One, what level the checking was at. **Two**, where names were deliberately left out. **Three**, what was cut entirely.

The third matters most. Almost no book prints it.

★ One · What level the checking was at

Honestly, in one line:

Several public sources cross-checked against each other.

Meaning: company announcements, disclosure filings, statistics published by public bodies, what a shop itself stated — found, and checked for contradictions.

And it stopped there.

This book did not open trademark registries, patent documents, original corporate filings, or weekly chart records.

So this is not primary-source verification. It's cross-checking.

Those are different things, and saying so is correct.

Of sixteen chapters, **eight** carry a **Where This Came From** section: 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 10, 11 and 12. The opening carries one too.

The other eight have none because **they contain no case to check**. Chapters 1, 2, 3, 9 and 13 through 16 are structure throughout.

★ Two · Where names were deliberately left out

This book almost never names a company or a product.

Two reasons.

One. Names age.

A name that's famous now may mean nothing in ten years, and then the sentence stops reading.

Two. Printing an unconfirmed name makes it a lie.

The second matters more.

Here's every place a name was deliberately left out.

Where	What isn't named	Why
Opening	the chain; the Kyoto rice cake shop	name rule (given in the sources)
Chapter 5	the 3D television makers	name rule
Chapter 7	when the trainer moved to everyday wear	not found
Chapter 8	the bottle trademark registration years	sources disagree
Chapter 10	the novel that entered the curriculum	couldn't be identified

Where	What isn't named	Why
Chapter 11	the military food's country and product	couldn't be confirmed
Chapter 12	song, singer and drama	name rule

Seven.

If you read something and thought "so what *was* it?" — it's probably here.

★ Three • What was cut entirely

The most important list.

Writing vaguely and moving on is the worst option. A reader takes a hedged sentence as fact.

So anything unconfirmed was cut whole, not softened.

One. That 3D came bundled into premium models (Chapter 5). Plausible and unconfirmed. Only the manufacturers' stated reason remains.

Two. Numbers for the fad curve being asymmetric (Chapter 4). It looks right as an observation and no data was found. The text says the data wasn't found and leaves it as an observation.

Three. A real example of a manufactured season (Chapter 9). Which company did what and when is recorded differently in different places. The example was cut and only the conditions remain.

Four. A case of a cost falling below a line (Chapter 10). The structure holds; no matching case was found. Structure only.

Five. Why that particular song was rediscovered (Chapter 12). Not a lack of data — it can't be said in principle. There's no way to count how many

songs met the same conditions and weren't.

Without the denominator there's no cause.

Six. That old customers left after the wave
(Chapter 12). No case could confirm it. Structure
only.

Six cut.

★ And one thing that isn't a case

Chapter 6 opens with three identical signs on one
street.

That's a scene, not a real case. The text says so.

Mixing those is not allowed, so **anything** that's a
scene is labelled a scene in this book. There's
exactly one.

★ What's different from the adult book

There's an adult book called *Why Is This Still Here?* Twenty chapters. This one has sixteen.

What changed:

Changed	How
Voice	direct address throughout
Chapters	twenty → sixteen
Chapter dropped	"Sold Few, Held Deep"
Cases swapped	things a teenager never saw → classroom equivalents
"One Line Today"	→ "Do This Today"

Why "Sold Few, Held Deep" was dropped.

Its conclusion is "depth gives lifespan and doesn't give a living." An adult reads that as "so put depth first in the order." A teenager reads it as "so doing this doesn't pay."

If the same sentence reads differently, don't print it. The one usable piece went into Chapter 16 instead: deep liking makes people talk without being asked.

★ Finally

Having written the lists out:

six things cut and seven names withheld.

The book would have been more fun without the cutting. Specific names and numbers read far better.

They were cut anyway.

A dull fact beats an entertaining lie. And writing down what you cut makes the dull part a bit more interesting.

Whatever you make, take this one thing from here.

Writing down what you don't know. It's the hardest part, and it lasts the longest.

Everyone Had One. Where Did They All Go? · The Teen Edition of
Why Is This Still Here?